

demonstrator, so he said, for the pastor. The only catch was that the odometer was disconnected while the pastor was using the car. Every six months he would return the one he was driving and get another new car, which seemed like a good deal at the time. In fact, it worked out so well that the friend negotiated a loaner for the pastor's wife too. Everything went great for about the first 9 or 10 months. Then one day an investigator from the State Attorney General's office came to the pastor's office. He asked to see his car and, upon noting that the odometer was disconnected, arrested him.

It seems that the church member had been renting out new cars to his friends, and since the odometers were disconnected when he reclaimed the cars six months later, he still sold them as "new" vehicles. These were all cash deals, so it was thought that no one would be the wiser.

The pastor convinced the investigators that he knew nothing about the illegal practice, but he still was responsible for the depreciation on the cars. Since he couldn't pay what was due, the authorities "suggested" he buy the cars. When he couldn't qualify to buy them, he signed a lease for both cars. The net result: \$500-a-month payments. The end result was that both cars went up for auction and the pastor owed the \$4,000 difference between the outstanding lease amounts and what the sales brought.

The temptation with many couples who should not buy new cars is to rationalize doing so because of the repair bills on their older cars. So they end up trading in an older car that costs \$75-100 a month to maintain for a new car that requires payments of \$200 or more a month. Remember, when you buy something on credit that you cannot afford, you don't avoid the decision; you delay it and ultimately make it worse. Don't get trapped into bondage by frustration over an uncooperative automobile. I would especially counsel against leasing an automobile. A lease is just as binding as a purchase agreement and usually a lot more costly. Too often a lease is selected because a couple can't even afford the down payment. The net result is more debt and more pressure.